The Lion and the Ox

A parable about two friends driven apart by the slander of a treacherous liar.

King Dabshalim of India said to Baydabā, his chief philosopher, "Tell me a parable about two friends driven apart by a treacherous liar who incited them to enmity and hatred." **4.1**

And Baydabā the Philosopher said, "When two friends fall victim to a treacherous liar who comes between them, they part company, turn their backs on each other, and sever relations. Here is a story to illustrate this."

In the land of Dastanābad there lived a rich merchant and his sons. When they came of age, his sons proceeded to squander their patrimony and pursued no gainful professions. Their father admonished them, saying, among other things, "My sons, a man in this world seeks three things, which can be obtained by only four means. The three things are: an ample livelihood, honor among men, and provision for the hereafter. The four means needed to obtain these three things are: acquiring wealth honestly; managing it well, once acquired; making it bear fruit; and spending it to enhance one's life, to please God, one's family, and friends, and to benefit oneself in the hereafter. If you neglect any of these four, you won't attain your desires. If you don't acquire, you'll have nothing to live on. If you acquire, but manage your wealth badly, it will soon disappear and you'll be left with nothing. If you spend it without investing it to bear fruit, it will be depleted quickly, however little you spend. It will be like kohl: you might only use a speck of it, but it disappears quickly. If you don't spend it where it ought to be spent, you'll be no better than a pauper; yet even this will not prevent your wealth from vanishing, be it by fate or by accident. It is like a cistern full of water: if more water pours in and there is no outlet to release the flow, the water will find a way to seep out, or it may even burst out all at once and everything will be lost." **4.2**

4.3

The Man Who Escaped from the Wolf

The merchant's sons took their father's advice to heart. The eldest set out for a land called Sūraqān to trade. On the way, he came to a place that was very muddy. He had a cart with him, drawn by two oxen: Shanzabah and Nandabah. Shanzabah sank into the mud. With the help of his assistants, the man managed to extricate him, but Shanzabah was exhausted. So the merchant's son left behind a man who was under orders to watch over the ox for a few days; when the man saw that Shanzabah had recovered, he was to bring him and catch up. But the next morning the man, tired of waiting, abandoned the ox, caught up with the merchant, and told him that the ox had died. The ox, for its part, set off and plodded on until he came to a grassy meadow, where he stayed, fearful that some inevitable misfortune might yet befall him—as happened, for example, to a man who, they say, was cutting hay when a wolf attacked him. Only when the wolf was near did the man notice and flee in terror toward a village on the bank of a river. When he reached the river, he found the bridge in ruins. With the wolf catching up, he said to himself, "What shall I do? The wolf is right behind me, the river is deep, the bridge is in ruins, and I can't swim. The safest thing is to entrust my life to the water." So he jumped in. The villagers saw him and pulled him out just as he was about to drown. Back among the villagers, as he leaned against a wall and began to tell them what had happened, the wall collapsed and killed him.

4.4

Shanzabah soon grew fat and flourishing, and, with his belly full of food, he began bellowing loudly. Nearby there lived a lion. As king of that region, he had an entourage of many wild animals: wolves, bears, jackals, foxes, and so forth. He was proud and given to relying only on his own judgment, which was far from perfect. When he heard the ox bellowing—he had never seen an ox or heard one bellow—he grew frightened, but not wanting his soldiers to notice, did not leave his place.

4.5

Among the animals in his entourage were two jackals, one named Kalīlah, the other Dimnah. Each was clever and intelligent, but of the two Dimnah was greedier, more ambitious, and less contented. The lion had not yet made their acquaintance. Dimnah asked Kalīlah, "Brother, what do you think is wrong with the lion? Why is he staying put, not stirring or showing his usual liveliness?"

"Why are you asking?" replied Kalīlah. "It's none of your business. Our situation here is good; here at the king's gate we find enough to eat. We're not the sort of people who converse with kings, discuss their affairs, and inquire into unknown matters. Enough of this! Anyone who interferes in things that are none of his business will suffer the same fate as the monkey."

"And what was that?" asked Dimnah.

4.6

The Monkey and the Carpenter

And Kalīlah told the following tale: A monkey, so they say, once saw a carpenter splitting a log using two wedges, straddling it like a knight on horseback. Whenever he split a cubit's length, he would drive in a wedge, sitting astride the log like a rider on a mount. At one point, the carpenter got up to relieve himself, and the monkey dashed over to try his hand at something that was none of his business. He straddled the log, with his back toward the split and his face toward the wedge,[18] with his testicles dangling in the split, and pulled out the wedge. When the wedge came out, the log closed with his testicles deep in the split. He fell over in a faint, and the beating he received from the carpenter was worse still.

4.7

"I see what you're driving at," replied Dimnah. "But people who approach kings don't do it only to fill their stomachs. Stomachs can be filled anywhere. People who approach kings seek eminence: a position that enables them to gladden their friends and rise above their enemies. The lowest sort of people, content with a pittance, are like the dog that rejoices at finding a dry bone. People of valor and merit aren't satisfied with little, or content with a pittance; their ambition aspires to what they deserve—like the lion who catches a hare, but as soon as he sees a wild ass, drops the hare and pursues the ass. Haven't you seen that a dog will wag his tail until he is thrown a crust, but a full-grown elephant, conscious of his strength and worth, won't eat even the best fodder until he is stroked and coaxed? Anyone who does not live in obscurity, a credit to himself and to his friends, lives a long life, however short his years. Anyone who lives life in solitude and scarcity, of little use to himself or others, lives a short life, however long his years. The worst lot, they say, is a long life lived in scarcity and distress. They also say that anyone interested only in his stomach is no different from cattle and sheep."

"I understand what you're saying," replied Kalīlah. "But think it over and consider your situation. Everyone has his place and measure. A person ought to be content and satisfied if he can hold his own. Our position is not so bad as to make us despise our present circumstances." **4.8**

"Positions," replied Dimnah, "can be contested and shared.[19] The industrious person's industry raises him from a lowly to a lofty place, but the person who lacks industriousness lowers himself from a lofty to a lowly place. It is difficult and taxing to rise from the depths to the heights, but easy to fall from a height. It is like a heavy stone: hard to lift onto your shoulder, but easy to drop. So we ought to aspire to a higher place, seeking it through our industry, and not stay where we are when we can rise higher."

"What have you decided to do?" **4.9**

"I intend to present myself to the lion straightaway. He's indecisive, and he and his soldiers are at a loss. I may be able to offer him good advice while he is in this state, and gain honor and glory in his eyes."

"What makes you think the lion is at a loss?"

"I know it by insight and by inference. A perceptive person can tell his companion's inward disposition from his visible demeanor and actions, and can infer it from his behavior and appearance."

"How do you hope to gain a place at the lion's court, when you've never rubbed shoulders with rulers and know nothing about how to serve them or behave in their presence?" **4.10**

"A strong person is equal to a heavy burden: if he can pick it up, he can carry it. No burden is too difficult for the strong, no work too arduous for the bold. An unfamiliar place poses no challenge for a person of intelligence, and no one can resist the blandishments of a person who pretends to be humble."

"A ruler doesn't bestow favor on the best of his courtiers; he honors them according to their closeness. They say that in this respect a ruler is like a grapevine, which clings not to the noblest but to the closest tree, just as **4.11**

women cling to the closest man. How do you expect to gain a place at the lion's court, when you've never been close to him?"

"I understand what you're saying, and you're right. But you must realize that those close to the ruler at present weren't always so: they had been distant from him and then became close to him and acquired standing. I, too, will make every effort to acquire standing with the lion. They say that no one can fail to obtain what he wants from the ruler if he perseveres at the ruler's gate, swallows his pride, bears insults, controls his anger, and treats important people with skill."

"I understand. But let's assume you've gained access to the lion: what is this 'skill' you hope to use to gain a place at his court?" **4.12**

"Once I'm close to the lion, I'll get to know his character. I'll defer to his wishes, humor him, and rarely disagree with him. When he wants something I think is right, I'll praise it, extol its benefits, and encourage him, so his delight with it increases. If he wants something I fear may bring harm and disgrace, I'll make him see the harm and disgrace in it. I hope that in this way the lion will become more and more fond of me and see in me what he sees in no one else. If you're cunning and skillful enough, you can turn truth into falsehood and falsehood into truth—like an accomplished artist who paints a wall with designs that seem to jut out from the wall, though they don't in reality, and designs that appear to recede, though they don't in reality. Once the lion recognizes my merits and knows what I have to offer, he'll be all the more eager to honor me and keep me close."

"If this is your plan," said Kalīlah, "I must warn you about the dangers of associating with rulers. Scholars say there are three things that only fools attempt and from which few escape unscathed: associating with rulers, trusting women with secrets, and drinking poison as an experiment. Scholars have likened a ruler to a steep, rugged mountain where all sorts of pleasant fruit grow, but which is home to lions, leopards, and every kind of ferocious beast—the ascent may be difficult, but staying there is harder yet." **4.13**

"That may be true," said Dimnah, "but without risk there is no reward. If we abandon a promising enterprise out of timidity or fear of the consequences, we shall never attain greatness. Three things, they say, can be accomplished only with knowledge, lofty ambition, and great danger: serving a ruler, sailing the seas as a merchant, and fighting an enemy. They also say that there are only two places where a man of great valor should be found: as an honored companion of kings or as a hermit in the company of ascetics—just like the elephant, whose majesty and beauty belong in only two places: either roaming free in the forest, or as a mount for kings."

"May God grant you success in your decision!"

So Dimnah set out, and when he arrived he greeted the lion. "Who is this?" inquired the lion of his courtiers. They told him Dimnah's name and the name of his father, and the lion said, "I used to know his father." He told Dimnah to approach, then asked, "Where have you been living?" **4.14**

"In readiness at the king's gate," Dimnah replied, "waiting for some matter to arise in which I could assist the king with my counsel and my services. There are many occasions when the assistance of someone who seems insignificant may be needed. No one, however lowly or insignificant, is without some use. A twig thrown on the ground can be used to scratch an itchy ear. A creature that knows the difference between gain and loss is even more likely to be of use."

The lion liked what he heard. Thinking that Dimnah might be blessed with good judgment and the ability to give sound advice, he turned to his courtiers and said, "Someone of intelligence and virtue may be of low station and obscure origin, yet his virtue will shine forth and be recognized, like a torch whose flame rises even if it is pointed downward." **4.15**

When Dimnah saw that the lion was pleased, he said, "The king's subjects and courtiers have a duty to acquaint him with whatever knowledge and virtue they possess and offer him their opinion and advice. Only in this way can the king know them and assign them to the positions they merit. They are like seeds of wheat or barley buried in the ground: no one can determine what kind they are until they sprout. Those attending the ruler should **4.16**

inform him of their usefulness and skills, and the ruler should assign each to his proper place, both according to that person's opinion and advice, and according to the usefulness and skills the ruler discerns in him.

"They say there are two things that no one, not even a king, should put in the wrong place or remove from where they belong: an ornament fashioned for the feet and an ornament fashioned for the head. Someone who puts a foot ornament on his head or a head ornament on his feet will be taken for a fool; someone who sets rubies and pearls in lead doesn't diminish their value, but he demonstrates his ignorance. They also say: Never take as your companion someone who doesn't know where to put his right foot and where to put his left. **4.17**

"Only a ruler can know a man's true potential, only a general can know a soldier's, and only a jurist can interpret religious law. Three things, they say, differ greatly in excellence though they are called the same thing: one soldier and another, one elephant and another, and one scholar and another. Many inexperienced helpers harm an enterprise: success depends on good helpers, not on their number. It is like a man who weighs himself down by carrying a heavy stone and gets nothing for it, while another carries a ruby that doesn't weigh him down and gets what he wants for it. Reeds, however many, are useless for a task that requires a beam. A ruler shouldn't despise anyone's virtues, however lowly, for something small can turn out to be of great importance, such as a sinew from a corpse used in a bow, which is then treated with dignity when brandished by a king in sport and war." **4.18**

Dimnah wanted the courtiers to know that any honor he received from the lion had not been conferred on him because the lion had known his father, but because of Dimnah's own intelligence and merit, so he said, "A ruler doesn't bring men near or keep them at a distance because of the respective positions of their fathers; he employs them according to the benefits each can bring. Nothing is closer to a man than his body, but sometimes part of it falls ill and only a medicine brought from afar can dispel the illness. The rat lives as a neighbor in the house, but when he causes damage he is driven out. The goshawk may be wild and from a distant land, but people acquire it, keep it, and treat it with honor because of its usefulness." **4.19**

When Dimnah finished his speech, the lion was even more pleased. Replying graciously, he said to his companions, "A ruler shouldn't deprive a deserving person of his due or lower the rank of a person of merit, and he should remedy any past negligence. He shouldn't be fooled by an aggrieved party's apparent acquiescence and acceptance. In this regard, people are of two kinds. Some are ill-tempered by nature, like a snake: if someone steps on it and it doesn't bite him, he shouldn't be foolish enough to step on it again. Others are easygoing by nature, like cool sandalwood; and yet, if rubbed too much, it becomes hot and noxious." **4.20**

When Dimnah felt confident that he had secured the lion's favor, he said, when he was alone with him, "I've noticed that the king has stayed put in one place for some time and hasn't moved. Why is that?" **4.21**

"That's true," said the lion. But not wanting Dimnah to learn of his cowardice, he added, "But there's nothing wrong."

Just as the lion was saying this, Shanzabah gave a loud bellow, startling the lion into revealing his state of mind to Dimnah: "That sound you hear, I don't know what it is, but the voice must be matched by the body, and the body be matched by its strength. If that's the case, we can't stay here."

"Has anything besides the voice troubled the king?" asked Dimnah.

"Nothing else," replied the lion.

And Dimnah said, "This sound shouldn't distress the king and make him abandon his home. As they say, water is the ruin of a weak dam, a leaky vessel the ruin of a secret, slander the ruin of friendship, and fright caused by a loud noise and commotion the ruin of a cowardly heart. There is a story that clearly demonstrates that not all noises are to be feared." **4.22**

"What story is that?" asked the lion.

4.23

The Fox and the Drum

And Dimnah told the following tale: A fox, they say, once came to a forest where a drum lay by a tree. When the wind blew, the tree's branches would strike the drum, producing a loud noise. The fox heard the sound and headed toward it. When he approached the drum and saw how big it was and how

loud the sound, he went to work on it, splitting it open in anticipation of a hearty meal. But when he discovered it was hollow, he said, "For all I know, the lowliest things have the biggest bodies and the loudest voices."

"I've told you this story because I expect that if we get to the source of this sound you find so disturbing, we shall find it to be less than we imagine. If the king wishes, he can send me to investigate, and stay here until I report back with information about the sound." The lion agreed, and Dimnah set off to find Shanzabah.

After Dimnah's departure, the lion thought things over and regretted having sent him to investigate. "I was wrong to trust Dimnah with such a mission. No ruler should hasten to befriend, trust, or confide in anyone who has stood waiting at the king's gate and long been treated coldly for no offence; or who has been harassed; or who is notorious for his greed and covetousness; or who has suffered misfortune or deprivation without amends; or who has committed a crime and fears punishment; or who is wicked and no lover of the good; or who has been barred from some authority or stripped of some property that he possessed; or who has held an office that was divided, reduced, or shared with someone else; or who has offended along with his peers, but who was punished when they were pardoned, or who were all punished, but he most severely of all; or who has proved his valor as well as his peers, but they received a greater reward; or who has a hostile, quarrelsome rival promoted over him; or who cannot be trusted in matters of religion; or who has sought to benefit personally from something harmful to his ruler; or who fears harm to himself from something beneficial to his ruler; or who has been friendly with the ruler's enemy. Dimnah is clever and shrewd. He has been left to languish at my gate and may bear me a grudge that could lead him to betray me and seek to harm me. If he finds that the owner of the voice is stronger and preferable to me as ruler, he may find his prospects brighter and go over to his side and point out my weaknesses." **4.24**

The lion pondered these things. Eventually he became so upset that he rose from his place and began pacing back and forth, watching the road. **4.25**

At last he caught sight of Dimnah approaching. When he saw that Dimnah was alone, he relaxed and made his way back, not wanting Dimnah to think that anything had prompted him to move. When Dimnah arrived, the lion asked, "How did it go and what did you see?"

"I saw an ox. His is the voice you heard."

"How strong and powerful is he?"

"Not strong at all!" replied Dimnah. "I saw no haughtiness that would indicate strength. I went up to him and addressed him as an equal. He wasn't strong enough or powerful enough to do anything to me."

"Don't let that fool you!" said the lion. "Don't attribute it to weakness! A strong wind doesn't uproot grass; it uproots mighty trees. Great warriors only challenge one another."

"The king should have no fear of him," said Dimnah, "nor exaggerate his importance. If the king wishes, I will bring him here to become Your Majesty's willing and obedient servant."

"Do it!" said the lion, delighted by Dimnah's words.

So Dimnah returned to the ox and said, with no fear or hesitation, "The **4.26**
lion has sent me to bring you to him. He has commanded me to say that if you come to him promptly and obediently, I am to promise you immunity for your past misconduct in lagging behind and failing to present yourself to him. If you delay, I am to hurry back and inform him accordingly."

"And who," asked Shanzabah, "is this lion who sent you to me? Where does he live?"

"He is the King of the Beasts," replied Dimnah. "He dwells nearby and has many fierce animals with him."

Frightened by the mention of the lion and the beasts, Shanzabah said, "I'll go with you if you guarantee my safety."

So Dimnah allayed his fears and they set out together. When they came before the lion, he asked Shanzabah politely, "When did you come to this land? What brought you here?" And Shanzabah told the lion his story.

"Stay with me," said the lion. "I will be generous and treat you well." Shanzabah invoked blessings upon the lion, praised him, and remained with him. The lion brought him into his inner circle, treating him with kindness and honor. Because he saw that Shanzabah had good judgment and intelligence, he trusted him with his secrets and consulted him in his affairs. Time only increased his admiration and esteem, and he drew Shanzabah closer and closer—so much so that Shanzabah's companions became envious of his closeness to the lion. **4.27**

Dimnah was consumed with envy when he saw that the lion favored the ox over him and the other courtiers; had allowed the ox private access to him, as well as to his evening conversations and entertainments; and relied on him for advice. He became so upset that he complained to his brother, Kalīlah, "Aren't you amazed at my foolishness, at what I've done to myself, how I only considered the lion's gain, overlooking my own gain and loss by bringing him an ox who has ousted me from my place?" **4.28**

"You've suffered the same fate as the ascetic," responded Kalīlah.

"And what was that?"

4.29

The Ascetic and the Thievish Disciple

And Kalīlah told the following tale: An ascetic, so they say, once received a splendid garment from a king. A thief noticed the garment and wanted it. Hoping to make off with it, he devised a way to steal it. He went to the ascetic and said, "I want to become your disciple, learn from you, and acquire some of your erudition." The ascetic agreed. The thief became his disciple and looked the part. He was courteous and served his master well. Once the master was comfortable with him and trusted him, the thief caught the ascetic off guard and made off with the garment.

4.30

The Fox and the Wild Goats

With both man and garment missing, the ascetic realized that the disciple must be the culprit. He searched his usual haunts, and then headed for the city in pursuit. On the way, he came across two wild goats that kept butting each other until they drew blood. A fox came to lap up the blood, and while he was busy lapping, the goats turned on him and butted him to death.

4.31

The Woman Who Kept Prostitutes

The ascetic continued on his way and arrived at the city. It was late in the evening, and the only lodging he could find was the house of a woman who kept prostitutes, so he stayed there. The woman had a maidservant, whom she used to hire out, but the girl had become so enamored of one man that

she didn't want to go with anyone else. Faced with the loss of the girl's earnings, the woman developed a grudge against the lover and devised a plan to kill him, on the very night the ascetic became a guest. She plied the lover with undiluted wine until he passed out and fell asleep with the girl beside him. When both were sound asleep, she took some poison she had prepared and put it into a hollow reed in order to blow it into the man's posterior. She put one end of the reed into his posterior and the other end into her mouth, but before she could do anything, a puff of wind from the man's posterior drove the poison back into her throat and she fell down dead. The ascetic saw everything.

4.32

The Shoemaker's Wife and the Barber's Wife

The ascetic set out early the next morning to find somewhere else to lodge. He was taken in by a shoemaker, who told his wife, "Watch over this ascetic; be generous to him and take good care of him. One of my close friends has invited me to a party." The shoemaker then departed. Now, the shoemaker's wife had a lover. Their go-between was a barber's wife.[20] The shoemaker's wife sent the barber's wife a message, asking her to go to the lover and tell him to come, as the shoemaker was out drinking with his friends and wouldn't be back until late, and would be drunk to boot. The lover arrived at dusk and sat by the gate waiting for the shoemaker's wife.

4.33

Late that evening, the shoemaker returned home drunk. He became suspicious and flew into a rage when he saw his wife's lover. He went into the house, grabbed his wife, beat her, and tied her to a post in the bedroom. When everyone was fast asleep, the barber's wife came over to her and said, "Your lover has been sitting by the door a long time! What do you plan to do?"

"Don't you see the state I'm in?" she replied. "If you'd be so kind as to untie me, I'll tie you up in my place for an hour, go to my lover, and come back as quickly as I can."

The barber's wife agreed, and she untied the shoemaker's wife and took her place. But the shoemaker awoke before his wife returned. He called out her name but the barber's wife, afraid he might recognize her voice, didn't reply. He called her and upbraided her repeatedly; still she made no reply. He got angrier and angrier, until he went at her with a knife and cut off her nose, saying, "Take this and go join your lover!"

When the shoemaker's wife came back and found her friend mutilated and her husband asleep, she released her friend and tied herself up in her place. The barber's wife picked up her nose and returned home. The ascetic saw and heard everything.

4.34 The shoemaker's wife raised her voice to God in prayer, beseeching Him, weeping, and calling to her husband: "If my husband has treated me unjustly, give me back my nose, whole as it was!" Then she called out to her husband: "Get up, you evildoer! See how God has undone your work and has had mercy on me. He has given me back my nose, just as it was." The shoemaker exclaimed, "What is all this talk, you witch?" He got up and lit a lamp, and when he looked at his wife and saw that her nose was whole, he repented to God and apologized to his wife, asking her to forgive him.

4.35 Back home, the barber's wife turned over every conceivable scheme in her mind. "What explanation can I present to my husband and to people for the loss of my nose?" Her husband awoke at dawn and called out to her: "Bring me my things! I want to pay a visit to an important customer." But the only thing she brought him was his razor. "My whole kit!" he repeated, but again she brought just the razor. The barber flew into a rage and hurled the razor at her, whereupon she threw herself to the ground, wailing, "My nose, my nose!" And she kept on shouting and crying out until her kinsmen came and hauled her husband off to the judge, who asked the barber, "What led you to cut off your wife's nose?" He had no argument to offer in his defense, so the judge ordered that he be punished.

Just as the barber was being led to his punishment, the ascetic arrived, and approached the judge. "There isn't any doubt about it!" the ascetic said. "It wasn't the thief who robbed me, it wasn't the wild goats who killed the fox, it wasn't the poison that killed the woman, and it wasn't the barber who cut off his wife's nose—we all did it to ourselves!" The judge asked the ascetic to explain, which he did.

4.36 Dimnah said, "I understand the story, and it does resemble my situation. Indeed, no one has harmed me but myself. But what's to be done now?"

"Tell me what *you* think."

"For the time being, I'm not seeking a higher place than before; I only want to regain what I had. There are three things a prudent man must take into account and work out how to deal with. He must consider past losses and gains, guarding against the recurrence of past losses and seeking ways to repeat past gains. Next, he must consider present gains and losses, striving with all his might for what results in profits and avoiding anything that results in losses. Finally, he must consider future gains he hopes for and future losses he fears, in order to obtain what he hopes for and guard against what he fears. When I consider how to recover the position that was wrested from me, the only remedy I can find is to scheme against this grass eater until the ox breathes no more. Once he has left the lion, not only do I regain my position, but it may also be better for the lion, as his excessive devotion to the ox is likely to disgrace him and spark resentment in most of his courtiers."

"But," said Kalīlah, "I see no disgrace or harm in how the lion views the ox or in the favored position he enjoys." **4.37**

"Not so!" replied Dimnah. "Six things can destroy a ruler: privation, sedition, self-indulgence, brutality, the adversity of fate, and folly. Privation is the loss or dismissal of aides, advisers, and administrators who possess good judgment, courage, and trustworthiness. Sedition is civil war and the outbreak of fighting among the people. Self-indulgence is infatuation with women, conversation, drinking, hunting, or anything of that sort. Brutality is excessive harshness, the tongue quick to revile, the hand quick to strike at the wrong time. The adversity of fate includes disasters such as famine, plague, flooding, poor harvests, and the like. Folly is resorting to harshness when leniency is required, and leniency when harshness is required. The lion has become too fond of the ox, and that, as I said, is likely to harm and disgrace him."

4.38 "But how can you overcome the ox when he's stronger than you, is shown more honor by the lion, and can count on more friends and supporters?"

"Pay no attention to my size. Things aren't always decided by strength and weakness. Many a small, weak creature has accomplished by cleverness, intelligence, and cunning what many strong, powerful creatures were unable to achieve. Haven't you heard how a crow outwitted the cobra and killed him?"

"How did that come about?"

4.39 *The Crow Who Outwitted a Cobra*

And Dimnah told the following tale: A crow, so they say, had a nest in a tree on a mountain, not far from a cobra's den.[21] Whenever the crow had chicks, the cobra went to the nest and ate them. When the cobra had done this many times, the distressed crow complained to a friend of his, a jackal: "I've decided to ask you about something I intend to do, to see whether you agree with me about it."

"What is it?" asked the jackal.

"I intend to go to the cobra while he's asleep and peck out his eyes."

"That's not a good plan," replied the jackal. "Find a way to defeat the snake without risking your life. Beware lest you suffer the fate of the heron[22] who wanted to kill the crab but ended up killing himself."

"How did that come about?" asked the crow.

4.40 *The Heron Who Would Kill a Crab but Killed Himself*

And the jackal told the following tale: A heron built his nest beside a pond teeming with fish. He lived there for a time, but then grew old and could no longer fish. Weary and hungry, he looked for ways to cope with the situation. One day he sat himself down and made a show of sadness. From afar, a crab saw the state he was in and how sad he was, so he approached and said, "I see that you're very dejected."

"How could it be otherwise?" replied the heron. "Up to now, I've sustained myself by catching one or two fish every day. It was enough for me to live on, and it didn't decrease the fish population. But today I saw two fishermen come by, and one said to the other, 'I think there are lots of

fish here. Why don't we catch them?' His companion said, 'I know a place with fish farther on. I think we should begin there; when we finish there, we can come back here.' I know that when they finish there, they'll come back and catch every single fish in this pond; if this happens, it will be the end of me."

The crab went to the community of fishes and informed them. They in turn went to the heron to seek his advice. "We've come for your advice," they said. "An intelligent person doesn't fail to ask his enemy for advice, if the latter has good judgment and both stand to lose or gain in the affair. Your judgment is good, and our survival is to your advantage, so give us your advice." **4.41**

"I don't think we can take on the fishermen and fight them," said the heron. "The only solution I can think of is a nice pond I've discovered with plenty of water, reeds, and vegetation. If you move there, you'll thrive and prosper."

"Who but you can do us that favor?" they asked.

"I will," he said.

So each day the heron would pick up two fish and carry them off to a hill, where he ate them. The rest of the fish had no idea what was happening. **4.42**

Then one day the crab came to the heron and said, "I, too, am worried about staying here. Take me to that pond."

The heron picked up the crab, planning to make him his meal for the day; but when he came to the hill where he would eat the fish, the crab looked down and saw piles of fish bones. Realizing that the heron was the offender and that he intended for him the same fate as the fish, he said to himself, "When you meet your enemy in a place where you know you'll die whether you fight or not, fight to save your honor." So he gripped the heron's neck with his pincers and squeezed so hard that the heron fell to the ground, taking the crab down with him. The heron died, but not the crab, who went back to the fish and told them what had happened.

The jackal said, "I've told you this tale to teach you that some schemes are fatal to the schemer. But I'll show you how you can bring about the cobra's death." **4.43**

"How?" he asked.

"Fly off and see if you can get hold of a valuable piece of women's jewelry. Snatch it and fly away in short bursts. Fly, then land, then take off again, so the people chasing you can keep you in their sights. When you reach the cobra's den, drop the jewelry there. When the people get there, they'll retrieve the jewelry and rid you of the cobra."

So the crow flew off and circled the sky looking for jewelry. He found a woman on a rooftop who had taken off her clothes and jewelry to bathe. He snatched a necklace and flew away, alighting from time to time so that he could be seen. When he reached the cobra's den, he dropped the necklace in full view of the people following him. They went to fetch the necklace and discovered the cobra there. They killed it and took their necklace. **4.44**

Dimnah said to Kalīlah, "I've told you this tale to demonstrate that ingenuity can accomplish what force cannot." **4.45**

"That would be so," replied Kalīlah, "if the ox didn't possess good judgment as well as strength, but he has good judgment and intelligence in addition to strength. How will you deal with that?"

"The ox, as you say, may be strong, powerful, and intelligent, but he's not on his guard against me and has no fear of me, so I'm likely to vanquish him, just as a rabbit once vanquished a lion."

"And how did he vanquish him?"

4.46

The Rabbit Who Vanquished a Lion

And Dimnah told the following tale: Once, they say, there lived a lion in a well-watered, fertile, grassy land. The animals there were surrounded by streams and pastures, but couldn't enjoy these blessings because of their fear of the lion. So they conferred among themselves, then went to the lion and said, "Every day you wear yourself out trying to catch one of us. We have an idea that will make things easier for you and for us. If you guarantee our safety and stop terrifying us, we promise to provide an animal every day and send it to you for your lunch."

The lion agreed. He made peace with them on these terms, and they honored their end of the bargain for a time. They drew lots every day and sent the unfortunate animal to the lion to be eaten, accompanied by an escort.

One day, a rabbit drew the short straw and she said to the others, "If you do me a favor—it won't harm you at all—I may be able to rid you of the lion." **4.47**

"What sort of favor?" they asked.

"Very simple," she said. "Command my escort not to hurry me along; I'll take my time, and the lion's lunch will arrive late. Also, tell my escort to lag behind, so I arrive alone."

"Agreed," they said, and the rabbit set off, taking her time. When it was past the lion's lunchtime, she approached at her leisure. The lion, hungry and angry because his lunch was late, had risen to his feet and was pacing back and forth. When he saw the rabbit, he said, "Where have you come from? And where are the animals?"[23] **4.48**

"I am the animals' messenger," she replied. "They dispatched me with a rabbit, but when I was close, a lion turned up and snatched her away, saying, 'I have a better claim to this land and its animals!' 'But this is the king's lunch!' I said. 'The animals have sent it to him. Don't make him angry!' But he cursed and reviled you. I've come as quickly as I could to bring you this information."

The lion grew angry. "Come with me," he said, "and show me this lion." So she took him to a deep well filled with clear water. "This," she said, "is the lion's lair. I'm afraid of him, but if you hold me in your arms I'll show him to you." So he held her in his arms. "Look down into the well," she said, "and you'll see the lion." He looked down and caught sight of his own reflection and the reflection of the rabbit in his arms. When he saw his and the rabbit's reflection, he leapt into the well and drowned, and the rabbit escaped. **4.49**

Kalīlah said, "If you can destroy the ox without harming the lion, go ahead and do it; his position has harmed me and you, as well as members of the army. But if you can't do it without harming the lion, don't do one at the expense of the other: that would be both betrayal and villainy." 4.50

Dimnah avoided the lion for a few days; then, with a show of cautious reserve, he turned up when the lion was alone. 4.51

"What's kept you away?" asked the lion. "I haven't seen you for a long time. Is everything all right?"

"I wish!"

"Has something happened?"

"Yes. Something neither of us wanted, Your Majesty."

"What is it?"

Dimnah replied, "A speaker who dares to deliver an unwelcome message is acting foolishly unless he trusts the intelligence of the person he is addressing. The person addressed, if intelligent, will tolerate the message and listen to it because it might alert him to a potential disaster. The speaker will bear with any frightful consequences for the sake of fulfilling a duty incumbent upon him. Trusting in Your Majesty's excellent judgment and patience, I dare to inform you of something that has come to my knowledge. Unwelcome as it may be, I am confident that you know my devotion to you and how I put your welfare ahead of mine. You might not believe what I'm about to tell you; nonetheless, when I call to mind how our lives as animals are bound up with your life, I can do no less than fulfill my duty to inform you, even though you haven't asked it of me and even though I fear you might not be pleased. To withhold advice from your ruler, conceal illness from your physicians, or withhold an opinion from your brethren is to betray yourself." 4.52

"What is it?" asked the lion. 4.53

"A reliable source has informed me that Shanzabah met secretly with your chief officers and said to them, 'I've gotten to know the lion and put his judgment, strength, and shrewdness to the test. As a result, it's clear to me that he is weak and lacks judgment, and that he and I are bound to have a falling

out.' When I heard this, I realized that Shanzabah was a deceitful traitor. You've honored him in every way and have made him your equal—this has finally incited him to this clear treachery and malice. He hopes that your kingdom will become his once you're out of the way, and he's sparing no effort in scheming against you. He has intelligence, good judgment, friends, and accomplices. They say that a king should strike down anyone he discovers who rivals him in rank, appearance, wealth, and followers; otherwise, he'll be the one who is overthrown.

4.54 "Your Majesty is experienced in worldly affairs and a good judge of them. I advise you to deal with the matter before it reaches a crisis. Don't wait for it to happen, lest it escape your control and cause irreparable damage. They say there are three kinds of people: prudent, quick-witted, and feckless. One kind of prudent person isn't confounded when trouble comes. He isn't thrown into confusion; he doesn't falter in his judgment, resourcefulness, and ingenuity—he hopes thereby to find a way out of trouble. Even more prudent is the person who is ahead of events and is prepared, who foresees an event before it happens, sizes it up, and looks for the means to deal with it as if it were already upon him. He stops the disease before it strikes and wards off trouble before it happens. The feckless person, on the other hand, hesitates and entertains vain hopes until he perishes. The story of the three fishes is an example of this."

"What happened to them?" asked the lion.

4.55 *The Three Fishes*

And Dimnah told the following tale: They say there was a pond where three big fishes lived: one quick-witted, one prudent, and one feckless. The pond was on a highland that was hardly ever visited. One day, however, two fishermen passed by, saw the three fishes, and decided to return with their net and catch them. At the sight of the fishermen, the most prudent of the three fishes became apprehensive and fearful: she immediately left the pond by following its outlet to the river. The quick-witted fish, less intelligent, put off devising anything until the fishermen returned. At the sight of them, she realized what they intended to do, but discovered that they had blocked the outlet. "I was careless," she said, "and this is the result. Now that I've been so careless, how can I save myself? Desperate last-minute schemes rarely succeed! But someone with intelligence doesn't despair or give up looking

for a solution!" So she played dead and floated on the water, belly up. The fisherman took her and, assuming she was dead, set her down on the ground between the pond and the river. She then jumped into the river and escaped. As for the feckless fish, she swam back and forth and was caught.

"I understand what you're saying," said the lion, "but I can't believe the ox would deceive me and wish to harm me after I've treated him so well. Why would he, when he has experienced no mistreatment at my hands?" 4.56

"But that," said Dimnah, "is the very thing driving him to it! Seeing as you've never mistreated him, and have favored him in every way and raised him to every rank, the only rank left for him to covet is yours! A low, incompetent person remains a useful counselor until he rises to a rank he doesn't deserve, but as soon he reaches it, he becomes dissatisfied; his loyalty turns into duplicity and his benevolence into treachery and harm, and he uses duplicity, treachery, and disobedience to seek an even higher rank. Such a low, ungrateful person serves the ruler and is loyal to him only out of fear or need; as soon as he feels himself secure and loses his fear, he reverts to his original nature—like a dog's curly tail that has been tied straight: as long as it is tied, it stays straight, but once released it goes back to being bent and crooked.

"Your Majesty, remember that anyone who doesn't accept the advice of his loyal advisers will regret his decision. He will be like a patient who abandons his doctor's prescription and follows his own appetites instead. A minister's duty is to inform the ruler of the facts, to benefit him and increase his renown, and to abstain from anything that would harm or disgrace him. The best brother flatters least when giving advice, the best deed has the most pleasing consequences, the best praise comes from the mouths of the righteous, the best governance is not mingled with arrogance, the best wife agrees with her husband, the richest of the wealthy aren't held prisoner by greed, the best friend never quarrels, and the best character traits promote the fear of God. They also say that a man who lays his head to rest on fire and lies on a bed of snakes is more likely to enjoy a sound sleep than someone who senses that his companion harbors enmity against him day and night. 4.57

The weakest king is the most remiss and least attentive to his affairs; the one who, like an elephant in rut, pays no attention to anything. He makes light of anything unexpected, and if an affair goes awry, he vents his wrath on his companions."

4.58 "You've spoken harshly," said the lion, "yet harsh words from a sincere adviser must be borne. But even if Shanzabah were my enemy, as you say, he couldn't harm me. How could he, a grass eater, harm me, a meat eater? For me, he's nothing more than food! I'm not afraid of him. What's more, how can I betray him when I've given him a promise of safety, honored him, and praised him in front of all my troops? If I begin to behave differently, I make myself look like a fool and break my own promise."

"Don't delude yourself," replied Dimnah, "by saying that he's nothing more than food for you and that you do not fear him. Even if Shanzabah can do nothing to you on his own, he'll use others to scheme against you. They say that if a guest of unproven character asks you for an hour's hospitality, beware lest evil befall you because of him, as happened to the louse."

"What happened to it?" asked the lion.

4.59 *The Louse and the Flea*

And Dimnah told the following tale: A louse, they say, lived for a time in a nobleman's bed. She would sip his blood while he slept and would crawl over him so gently that she escaped notice. One night, a flea asked to be her guest and the louse agreed: "Spend the night with us. You'll enjoy tasty blood and a soft bed." So he did. But when the man got into bed, the flea gave him such a vigorous bite that it woke him up. The man ordered that the bed be thoroughly checked. During the search, the flea got away, but they found the louse and killed her.

4.60 "I've told this story to show Your Majesty that one can never be safe from a troublemaker; even if he's too weak to do anything himself, disaster may come about because of him. Although you don't fear Shanzabah, I worry about those in your army whom he has incited to hostility and emboldened against you. Still, I know that he himself will inevitably clash with you and will entrust the affair to no one else."

Dimnah's words made a deep impression on the lion. "What do you advise?" he asked.

"A rotten tooth," replied Dimnah, "causes pain until it is pulled. The way to get relief from a food that makes you nauseous is to throw it up. The remedy for an enemy you fear is to get rid of him."

"You've given me doubts—I don't want Shanzabah living anywhere near me. I'll send him a message about how I feel and command him to go elsewhere."

Dimnah wasn't pleased. He knew that if the lion spoke with Shanzabah **4.61** and heard his defense, he would realize that there was no substance to the matter; that Dimnah had been lying, and his scheme would be exposed. So Dimnah said to the lion, "I don't think it wise to send Shanzabah a message and bring up his offense. Consider the matter, Your Majesty. You have the advantage as long as Shanzabah has no idea that you've received word of his actions. If he senses that you have, I'm afraid he'll immediately try to get the better of you. If he fights you, he'll fight well prepared; if he leaves you, he'll leave in a way that shows his superiority and that brings you shame. Furthermore, prudent kings do not inflict public punishment on those whose offense has not become public. Every crime has its punishment: secret punishment for a secret crime, public punishment for a public crime."

"A king who punishes or humiliates someone on suspicion," said the lion, **4.62** "without being certain about the crime, punishes and humiliates no one but himself."

"In that case," replied Dimnah, "let Shanzabah come into your presence only when you're ready. Don't let him catch you off guard. If you look at him when he arrives, I'm sure you'll see that he's planning to do something terrible. Look for these signs: see if his color changes and his muscles twitch; see if he looks right and left, waving his horns as if preparing to gore."

"I'll be on the alert," said the lion. "If I see the signs you've mentioned when he enters, there'll be no doubt about what he intends."

Once Dimnah had incited the lion against the ox and was satisfied that he **4.63** had put the thoughts he wanted into his mind, so that the lion would be alert and ready for the ox, he wanted to go to Shanzabah to incite him against the

lion. But he wanted this done by the lion's command; he did not want the lion to learn about the meeting from someone else and become suspicious. So he said to the lion, "Why don't I go and see Shanzabah and listen to what he's saying? Maybe I can learn some of what he has in mind." The lion gave his permission.

Dimnah set off. He appeared before Shanzabah, pretending to be sad and dejected. Shanzabah welcomed him as soon as saw him: "I haven't seen you for days! What's kept you away? Is everything all right?" **4.64**

"How can everything be all right," replied Dimnah, "when you're not your own master; when your fate lies in the hands of a person who can't be trusted and of whom you're in such constant fear and danger that not a moment goes by without you fearing for your life?"

"What has happened?" asked Shanzabah. **4.65**

"What was fated to happen has happened—and who can fight fate? Can anyone attain greatness in this world without being destroyed or becoming insolent? Can anyone follow desire without coming to a bad end? Can anyone keep company with women without being seduced? Can anyone beg from churls without being humiliated? Can anyone consort with evildoers and escape safely without regret? Can anyone serve a ruler and remain in his good graces? How right the one who said that rulers, in their scant loyalty to companions and abandonment of those they no longer need, are like a whore with her customers: when one leaves, another takes his place!"

Shanzabah responded, "Your words make me fear that something has filled you with misgivings about the lion."

"Something has indeed filled me with misgivings, but it doesn't concern me personally," said Dimnah.

"Who then?" asked Shanzabah. **4.66**

"You know the claim you have on me," said Dimnah, "and the affection between us, and the promise of protection I gave you when the lion sent me to you. So now I must protect you and tell you what I've learned that makes me fear for you."

"What is it?" asked Shanzabah.

"A reliable source has informed me that the lion said to one of his companions, 'I like how fat this ox has become. Since I don't need him, I think

I'll eat him and we can feed his meat to my companions.' As soon as I heard this, I realized his ingratitude and wickedness. I've come to inform you and do my duty by you, so that you can devise a subtle and clever plan for yourself."

4.67

The Duck Who Mistook the Reflection of a Star for a Fish

When the ox heard these words, he recalled the solemn promise Dimnah had once made to him. Thinking about the lion and believing that Dimnah had given a true account of his intentions, he became worried. "It isn't right for the lion to act so treacherously when I've never offended him or any of his troops. Lies must have turned him against me and made him suspicious. The lion has bad companions, and they've made him believe what has been reported to him about others. Bad company often makes you suspicious of good people; it leads you to make the same mistake as the duck who, they say, saw the reflection of a star in the water and, thinking it a fish, tried to catch it. After repeated tries, she realized that it was nothing. The next evening, she saw a fish there, but didn't try to catch it, thinking it was like the previous occasions.

4.68

"It is understandable if the lion has believed the lies he has been fed about me because of his prior experience with others. But it is utterly amazing if he has received only good reports about me and wishes me ill for no reason. They say that it is strange when you seek to please your companion and he isn't pleased, but even stranger when you seek to please him and he becomes angry. Reconciliation can be hoped for when anger occurs for a cause; but there is no hope for reconciliation when it occurs without a cause. If anger is occasioned by the occurrence of a cause, then reconciliation can be hoped for when the cause ceases. Causes come and go, and exist for a while, but what is gratuitous lasts and never ceases.

4.69

"When I reflect on the matter, I can find no offense I've caused the lion, and if there was one it must have been small. By God, if you associate with a companion for a long time, you can never be so cautious as to avoid inadvertently doing something, small or great, that will displease him. A reasonable person ponders the magnitude and seriousness of an offence or mistake;

he considers whether it was intentional or accidental, and whether pardoning it may incur some harm or shame. He will not hold anything against his companion that he can possibly forgive.

"If the lion thinks I've committed an offense, I don't know what it could be, other than opposing him in some of his ideas, out of consideration and in the form of sincere advice. Perhaps he takes it as insolence or disobedience when he says no and I say yes, or when he says yes and I say no. But I don't think I should be faulted for that. I disagreed with him only when by doing so I could foresee success, benefit, and renown for him. I never spoke to him about such matters openly in the presence of his soldiers or before his companions; I met him privately and spoke to him as a respectful servant obedient to his master. I know that to seek to be indulged by comrades when asking for advice, or by doctors when one is sick, or by scholars over an obscure point of religion, is to fail to benefit from their advice. **4.70**

"If it isn't this, perhaps it's the sort of thing rulers do in moments of intoxication. Sometimes, in such moments, they favor those who deserve their anger and become angry with those who deserve their favor—all for no discernible reason. As has been said: To sail the sea is to run a risk, but to be a ruler's companion is to run an even greater risk. Though you attend on him with loyalty, uprightness, affection, and good counsel, you're still liable to stumble and fall, or to be lifted only when you're on the verge of destruction. **4.71**

"If it isn't this, perhaps some excellence of mine has been my downfall. A heavily laden tree may be ruined because of its load, and the sweetness of its fruit may become its undoing. A peacock's tail—his pride and glory—may be his undoing as it weighs him down when he needs to escape his pursuers. A sturdy steed may be ridden so hard and become so worn out that he perishes. A virtuous man's excellence may cause his downfall because so many rogues envy him and seek to do him harm. Those who lack excellence are more numerous than those who possess it; the wicked **4.72**

everywhere outnumber the good and soon destroy a good man if they turn against him.

"If it's not this, then it is fate, which cannot be repelled. Fate strips the lion 4.73
of his strength and vigor, and puts him in a cage. Fate mounts the weakling on the elephant's back, and gives the charmer mastery over the snake, extracting its venom, and playing with it as he pleases. Fate renders the resourceful inept and the inept resourceful. Fate frustrates the bold and emboldens the timid; it enriches the poor and impoverishes the wealthy; it instills courage into the coward and makes cowards of the courageous. Predetermined events take place in accordance with the means, occasions, and causes by which their courses have been determined."

"The lion's designs on you are not due to any of the reasons you've men- 4.74
tioned," replied Dimnah, "such as incitement by villains, the intoxication of power, or anything of the sort. Rather, they are due to his treachery and injustice. He's a treacherous tyrant: one's first taste of him is sweet, one's last taste bitter—a lethal poison."

"Yes," said Shanzabah, "I tasted the sweetness and found it delicious, but now I see that I've reached the lethal part. I don't think my staying with the lion was a good idea, he being an eater of meat, I an eater of grass. A plague on greed and expectation! They've made me fall into this quagmire and kept me from going my way—like a bee on a lotus flower: delighted by the scent, she becomes oblivious to when she needs to fly away, before the lotus closes its petals, so she is caught and dies. A slave to greed, who isn't satisfied with what is sufficient for this life, but sets his eyes on excess and fails to see the perils lying before him, is like a fly that isn't content with trees and herbs, but seeks the liquid that flows from the ears of an elephant in rut, and the elephant kills it with a flap of his ear. To offer advice to an ungrateful person is like sowing seeds in brackish ground: the advice is offered to a self-satisfied know-it-all; or it's like engaging a deaf man in debate."

"Enough talk!" said Dimnah. "Do something to save your life." 4.75

"How can I save myself if the lion wants to kill me?" said Shanzabah. "I know his character and how he thinks. I also know that even if he only wished me well, his wicked companions, with their guile, would prevail if they incited him against me and wanted me to perish at his hands. When

crafty villains unite against an innocent blameless person, they are likely to destroy him, even if they are weak and he is strong—just as the wolf, the crow, and the jackal destroyed the camel when they turned their wiles and deceptions against him."

"And how did they do that?" asked Dimnah.

4.76 *How the Wolf, the Crow, and the Jackal Destroyed the Camel*

So Shanzabah told the following tale: Once, they say, there lived a lion in a forest beside a well-traveled road. He had three companions: a wolf, a jackal, and a crow. One day, when some merchants were passing along the road, one of their camels lagged behind and wandered into the forest and encountered the lion. "Where have you come from?" asked the lion, and the camel told him his story. "What do you want?" asked the lion. "Whatever Your Majesty commands," replied the camel, and the lion said, "If you wish to become my companion, do so and enjoy abundance, safety, and comfort."

4.77 The camel lived with the lion until, one day, the lion went out hunting and encountered an elephant in rut. They fought fiercely. Wounded by the elephant's tusk, the lion returned bleeding and fell sick, unable to hunt. The wolf, the jackal, and the crow became emaciated with hunger because they could not enjoy the lion's leftovers on which they usually dined. The lion, who realized what was happening, said, "You are suffering and need something to eat," and they replied, "When we see the king's condition, we do not worry for ourselves. If only we could find the king something to restore his health!" The lion said, "I don't doubt your loyalty. If you can, spread out and search. Perhaps you'll find some game nearby. Let me know, so I can provide us all with sustenance."

4.78 The wolf, the crow, and the jackal left the lion and went aside to confer. "What do we have in common with this grass eater, this camel?" they asked. "His nature isn't like ours, nor are his habits. Why don't we convince the lion to eat him and feed us some of the meat?"

To which the jackal replied, "We can't propose this to the lion, because he has promised the camel safety and granted him protection."

"Stay here," said the crow, "and let *me* deal with the lion."

4.79 The crow went to the lion. "Well?" asked the lion on seeing him. "Have you spotted anything?"

"You can't find if you can't seek," replied the crow, "and you can't see if you don't have sight. We're so hungry that we can hardly walk or see. We do, however, have a proposal on which we're all agreed. If Your Majesty approves, we shall all have much to eat."

"And what is it?" asked the lion.

"This grass-eating camel," the crow answered, "who lazes about among us with nothing to do!"

This made the lion angry. "Shame on you! What a sinful thing to say! **4.80** What a terrible idea! What happened to loyalty and mercy? How dare you confront me with such a proposal! Don't you know that I solemnly promised the camel safety and protection? Haven't you heard that a benefactor can bestow no gift, however great, more meritorious than to extend protection to a fearful soul and save its life? I have granted the camel my protection; I will not betray him."

The crow said, "I understand what Your Majesty is saying, but a single life is sacrificed to save a family, a family to save a tribe, a tribe to save a city's inhabitants, and a city's inhabitants to ransom a king. Now that need and disaster have descended on both the king and us, I will give the king a way out. Your Majesty will not be personally responsible for any betrayal of the camel, nor for commanding it. We will devise a way for the king to keep his promise and for us to obtain what we need." The lion kept silent.

Interpreting this as a sign of agreement, the crow returned to his friends. **4.81** "I talked to the lion until he agreed to some such thing. But how do we deal with the camel if the lion refuses to kill him himself or to order his companions to do so?"

"We'll rely on your skill in the matter," replied his friends.

"Here is my plan," said the crow. "We meet with the camel. We mention the lion's hunger and exhaustion. We say, 'He's given us everything we need and been generous to us. If in his day of need he doesn't see how worried we are about him and how concerned for his welfare, he'll take it as ingratitude and baseness on our part. Let's go before the lion and speak of the favors he's bestowed on us; let us describe how, if we can acquire anything that will be

of use to him, we will bring it to him, holding nothing back; and how, if we fail, our very lives are his to dispose of. Let's each of us offer himself, saying, "Eat me, Your Majesty! Don't die of hunger!" When we say this, the others will respond with a reason to reject the offer, and so we shall all be safe. In this way, we shall have fulfilled our duty to the lion and he will be pleased with us.'"

They met with the camel, and he agreed to their plan.

When they came before the lion, the crow spoke first: "Your Majesty, you need something to sustain you in your distress, so it behooves us to offer up our lives in order to preserve yours. After all, it is through you that we have lived and through you, we hope, that our offspring may live. If you perish, none of us will survive and our lives won't be worth living." **4.82**

"Shut up," replied the wolf and the jackal. "How will offering your life do any good, when there isn't enough in you to satisfy the king's hunger?"

"But I will satisfy the king!" said the jackal.

"Your breath is putrid and your belly is filthy," said the wolf and the crow.

"I'm not like that!" said the wolf. "Let the king eat me!"

"Anyone looking to commit suicide should eat wolf meat. He'll choke to death on it!" said the crow and the jackal.

The camel thought that if he made the same offer, they would find him an excuse, just as they had done for themselves; he would be safe and the lion would be pleased. So he said, "There is enough in me to satisfy the king's hunger; my innards are tasty and my flesh is wholesome." **4.83**

"Well spoken!" said the wolf, the crow, and the jackal. "How noble! You've said what we know to be true!"—and they pounced on him and tore him to pieces.

Shanzabah said, "I've told you this parable with reference to the lion and his companions because I know that if they unite to destroy me I couldn't protect myself, even if the lion's opinion of me were not what it has been until now. The best rulers, it is said, are those who are like vultures surrounded by carrion, not those who are like carrion surrounded by **4.84**

vultures.[24] Even if the lion's heart harbored nothing but benevolence and mercy, much malicious talk would soon erase those feelings and replace them with cruelty and harshness. Water, you know, is softer than speech, and rock harder than the heart, but if water drips long enough on rock, it soon makes its mark."

"What do you intend to do?" asked Dimnah. **4.85**

"I see no way but to fight him," said Shanzabah. "You can devote your whole life to prayer, almsgiving, and asceticism, and still not obtain the reward obtained in a mere two hours by a just fighter defending his life. Whoever fights to defend his life from someone who would wrongfully deprive him of it achieves great reward and great renown: if he is slain, he achieves Paradise; if he slays, he achieves reward and victory."

"No one should risk his life unnecessarily," replied Dimnah. "If you perish, you've thrown your life away, and if you're victorious, it is due to the workings of fate. The wise man makes fighting his last resort, preferring skill and cunning whenever possible. I don't think you're right. You should fight your enemies only after exhausting every other strategy. Hastening to fight before it is warranted is overconfidence, rashness, and light-headedness; you should fight only in response to an opponent who makes the first move. Otherwise, if you kill your enemy you will be thought to have acted rashly, and if you are killed you will have sinned and earned punishment in the afterlife. It has been said: Don't disparage a lowly, weak opponent, especially a crafty one—let alone the lion, with all his boldness and strength! I have learned that to disparage an enemy for his weakness is to suffer the fate of the Sea's Custodian at the hands of the shorebird Ṭīṭawā."[25]

"And what was his fate?" asked Shanzabah.

4.86

The Shorebird Ṭīṭawā and the Sea

And Dimnah told the following tale: They say that a shorebird, the kind called Ṭīṭawā, had his nest by the sea with his mate. When it came time for them to raise their brood, the female said to the male, "It's time for me to lay eggs. Find me a safe place—I am fearful of the Sea. If he comes with the full force of his water, he'll sweep away our chicks."

"Why not right here?" replied the male. "We have water and reeds nearby; our home here is very comfortable."

"Fool, consider what you're saying! I'm afraid of this place—if the Sea rises, he'll carry off our chicks."

"I doubt the Sea would ever act so recklessly against us, because of the punishment he fears," replied the male.

"What boastful words!" said the female. "Aren't you ashamed of threatening the Sea? Have you so little knowledge of who you are to threaten him? How true what they say—nothing is harder than self-knowledge. Mark my words and move away from this place."

But the male refused to obey her. She repeated her request many times, but still he wouldn't listen. Then she said, "Those who disregard good advice are likely to suffer the fate of the turtle when she didn't accept the advice of her friends."

"And what was her fate?" he asked.

4.87

The Ducks and the Turtle

And the female told the following tale: They say that a pond was home to two ducks and a turtle. Being neighbors, they had become fast friends. One season, the water in the pond sank dangerously low. When the ducks saw the water recede, they said, "We'd better leave this pond and move elsewhere."

They said goodbye to the turtle: "Farewell! We're leaving."

And the turtle said, "Drought is an especially great hardship for a poor creature like me who can only live in water. You, however, can live wherever you go. Please find a way to take me with you."

"We'll take you with us on one condition," they replied. "Promise that if we carry you up into the air and people see you, talk about you, and shout at you, you won't answer."

The turtle promised not to reply to anyone. "But how," she asked, "will you carry me?"

"Bite onto the middle of a stick," they said, "and we'll take hold of the ends and lift you into the air."

The turtle agreed, and off they flew. When people saw them, they cried out, "Look at that marvel! A turtle in the air, between two ducks!"

When the turtle heard their words, she became angry and said, "May God poke out your eyes!" As soon as she opened her mouth and spoke, she fell to the ground and died.

The male Ṭīṭawā said, "I hear what you're saying, but you needn't be afraid of the Sea." So the female hatched her chicks where they were. **4.88**

Now, when the Sea's Custodian heard of this, he wanted to determine the extent of the male Ṭīṭawā's ability to protect himself and how he would manage to do it, so he waited until the tide rose, and carried off the Ṭīṭawā's chicks, along with the nest. Bereft of her chicks, the female said to the male, "I knew from the start that this would happen and that your lack of self-knowledge would cause us harm. Just look at what's happened to us!"

"I said to you at the beginning, and I say it to you now," replied the male, "that if the Sea behaved foolishly toward us, I would take revenge. You'll see what I'm going to do and how I'm going to get even."

He went to his comrades and complained about how he had been treated by the Sea: "You are my brothers, comrades I trust to help me seek redress. Assist me. Devise a plan for me. What happened to me today might also happen to you." **4.89**

"We'll help you to get what you seek," they replied, "but what can we do to the Sea?"

The Ṭīṭawā said, "Let's assemble all the birds and complain to them about how the Sea has treated us. We'll say to them, 'You are birds like us. Help us, because what has happened to us today might happen to you tomorrow.'"

So the male Ṭīṭawā assembled all the birds in one place and complained to them about how he had been treated by the Sea. "We're ready to help you," they said, "but what can we do to the Sea?" **4.90**

"We birds will go as one to the palace of the Phoenix of the West," said the Ṭīṭawā. "We'll cry and cry as loudly as we can, and call out to her until she sees us and forces the Sea to make amends!"[26]

That is what they did, and the Phoenix responded to them with a question: "What has brought you together, and why do you summon me?" They complained to her about the Sea. "You are our leader," they said, "and the king who rides mounted upon you is stronger than the Custodian of the Sea. Go and ask him to help us against the Sea!" **4.91**

And the Phoenix did so. She went to the king who rides her and asked him to fight the Sea. When the Sea realized his weakness compared with the strength of the king who rides the Phoenix, he immediately returned the Ṭīṭawā's chicks and never again touched the Ṭīṭawā's home.

"I've told you this story because it wouldn't be good for you to fight the lion, and I don't think you should do it." 4.92

"I won't fight the lion," said Shanzabah, "or make any hostile moves, either secretly or openly. I'll be on my best behavior toward him, unchanged in any respect, unless there is an obvious threat to me."

Dimnah was displeased when Shanzabah said that he wouldn't change his behavior toward the lion. He thought he would fall under suspicion if the lion didn't see in Shanzabah any of the signs he had described, so he said, "Go! As soon as you look at the lion, you'll see things that will make you uneasy."

"How will I know?" asked Shanzabah.

"If when the lion looks at you," said Dimnah, "he sits up on his haunches, raises his chest, stares at you, pricks up his ears, opens his mouth wide, and beats the ground with his tail, you can be sure he intends to kill you."

"If I see these signs in him, what you're saying will be beyond a doubt," replied Shanzabah.

Dimnah went to Kalīlah as soon as he was done turning the lion against the ox, and the ox against the lion. "How has your project progressed?" Kalīlah asked. 4.93

"It's about to turn out just as I wish," Dimnah replied. "No doubt about it! Don't imagine that the brotherhood between friends can hold. When a clever schemer uses his wiles to separate them, he can slice them apart just as a stone slices through water."

Kalīlah and Dimnah went together to visit the lion. Shanzabah entered just as they arrived. When the lion saw him coming, he sat up on his haunches, pricked up his ears, opened his mouth wide, and beat the ground with his tail. The ox, certain that the lion intended to kill him, said to himself, "A ruler's companion is never safe from the shifts in his master's moods and the changes in his attitude due to the influence of malicious liars. He is like a man who shares his bed with a snake, not knowing when it will attack him, or one who lives with a lion in his den, or one who swims in a lake with crocodiles—he doesn't know when he will be attacked." Such were his thoughts as he prepared to fight the lion, should the lion so desire. 4.94

As soon as the lion saw how the ox was behaving and perceived all the signs mentioned by Dimnah, he was certain that the ox had come to fight him. So he pounced on him and a fight ensued. The lion and the ox fought long and hard, until both were covered in blood. **4.95**

When Kalīlah saw the lion bleeding and understood what he had endured from the ox, he said to Dimnah, "You wretch, look at your clever scheme now! How despicable! What an evil outcome!"

"And what evil outcome do you see?" asked Dimnah.

Kalīlah replied, "The lion's disgrace, the ox's destruction, and the sowing of discord in the army—to say nothing of your evident clumsiness in matters where you claimed to have skill. Don't you know that the worst foolishness is that which leads to unnecessary fighting? Don't those in a position to fight often avoid it, in fear of danger or defeat, hoping to attain their objective by other means? A minister who orders war when the objective can be achieved peacefully is more harmful to his ruler than an enemy. Just as the tongue can be crippled by a disorder of the heart,[27] so can courage be crippled by misjudgment. Courage and judgment need each other: alone, without their comrade, they are useless in battle. But good judgment is superior to courage, as there are many matters in which good judgment will serve without might, whereas might alone can achieve nothing in the absence of good judgment. Someone who wants to use cunning, but doesn't know every detail of a matter he embarks on, will act as you have in your insolence and conceit. **4.96**

"Ever since I saw your greed and heard your talk, I have been expecting you to bring disaster and disgrace on us both. A wise man begins by reflecting on matters and actions before embarking on them: he proceeds with those he hopes will work out as he wishes and avoids becoming embroiled in those he fears will not.

"The only thing that prevented me from restraining you from the start and acquainting you with your faults was that it was something I couldn't make public for want of witnesses and supporters. Also, I knew that my words wouldn't make you a better person or turn you away from your desires. Now, however, I will tell you about yourself and acquaint you with your faults, for your misjudgment and clumsiness have become clear to me and I have seen **4.97**

their evil consequences. You are good at talking, but bad at action. Nothing, they say, is more dangerous to a ruler than a companion who is good at talking, but bad at action. Your fine words beguiled the lion, but your ineptitude caused his downfall. Words without deeds; theory without experience; wealth without generosity; friendship without loyalty; abstinence without piety; almsgiving without good intentions; and life without health, safety, and happiness—there is no good in any of these.

4.98 "You have stirred up an affair that only the wise and skillful can remedy—just as only a skilled physician can cure a patient who suffers from corruption of the bile, the wind, the blood, and the phlegm all at the same time. Learning sobers the wise, but intoxicates the fool—just as daylight sharpens the sight of every creature that can see, but dulls the sight of a bat. A wise man is not puffed up by office or honor, however great: he is like a mountain, unshaken even in a gale.

4.99 "Your case reminds me of something I've heard: They say that a ruler's goodness will be inaccessible if he is good but his ministers are evil, as no one will dare approach him. He will be like a pool of pure water harboring a crocodile: you can't enter it, even if you can swim or need water. A numerous and prosperous entourage is a king's crowning glory, but you have desired that only you, and no one else, should have access to the lion. You wanted no one else to enjoy any standing with him, whereas the ruler and his companions are like the sea and its waves. How stupid and foolish it is to seek friends by means of disloyalty, seek reward by means of hypocrisy, seek a woman's love by means of boorishness, seek one's own benefit by means of harm to others, or seek knowledge and virtue by means of sloth and indolence. But what's the use of all this preaching and instruction? I know that it's just as when the man once said to the bird, 'Don't try to put straight what cannot be straightened, or instruct those who will not be instructed!'"

"And how was that?" asked Dimnah.

4.100 *The Monkey, the Firefly, and the Bird*

And Kalīlah told the following tale: Once, they say, a band of monkeys who lived on a mountain saw a firefly on a cold night.[28] Thinking it was a spark, they collected firewood, piled it on her, and began blowing on it with their mouths and fanning it with their hands. A bird sitting in a nearby tree

called to them, "Don't tire yourselves out! What you saw isn't fire." But they wouldn't be deterred. Losing patience, the bird flew down to come closer to the monkeys and set them straight. A man who happened to be passing said, "Bird, don't try to set straight what cannot be straightened or instruct those who cannot be instructed! You don't test a sword on a rock that can't be split with an ax, and you don't try to bend brittle wood. To labor over what cannot be straightened is to regret it." But the bird refused to heed him. He approached the monkeys, and one of them grabbed him, dashed him on the ground, and killed him.

4.101 "This is exactly the way you are when it comes to how little you benefit from instruction and admonition. Furthermore, deceitfulness and boasting are the keynotes of your character: both are bad, though deceitfulness entails worse consequences. This is illustrated by what happened to the swindler who was the simpleton's partner."

"And what happened to him?" asked Dimnah.

4.102 *The Swindler and His Partner the Simpleton*

And Kalīlah told the following tale: Once, they say, a swindler and a simpleton became business partners. While they were walking on the road, the simpleton lagged behind and found a purse containing a hundred thousand dinars. He picked it up and told the swindler about it. They decided to head back home.

Close to town, they sat down to divide the money. "You take half, and give me half," the simpleton said to the swindler. But the swindler, intent on taking it all, said, "Let's not divide it: partnership and joint ownership are more conducive to familiarity and friendship. You take some, I'll take the same amount, and we'll bury the rest somewhere safe. When we need the rest, we'll come back together and get what we need."

"Fine," said the simpleton. So they took some of the money and buried the rest by the root of an imposing tree. Afterward, the swindler, unbeknownst to the simpleton, came back to the tree, made off with all the money, and leveled the ground over the spot.

4.103 A few days later, the swindler said to the simpleton, "We need to pay some expenses. Why don't we go and get some more of the money?" So they set out together. They dug up the spot, but found nothing. The swindler began tearing his hair and beating his breast, and cried out, "Let no man

trust his brother or be fooled by his companion! Did you come back and take the money?" The simpleton became angry and swore he hadn't, but this only made the swindler more incensed. "Who else could have taken it?" he asked. "Does anyone else know about it?"

4.104 The swindler grabbed the simpleton and hauled him before the judge, and they told their story. The swindler claimed that the simpleton was the one who had taken the money.

"Have you any evidence?" asked the judge.

"Yes," said the swindler. "The tree where the money was buried will testify for me!"

The judge, incredulous and amazed at the idea of calling a tree to testify, ordered that the swindler place himself in the custody of a bondsman,[29] and said to the bondsman, "Bring him to me tomorrow, so I can learn the truth about his claim that the tree will testify."

4.105 The swindler then returned home and told his father the story. "Father," he said, "I called the tree as a witness because I have a plan. I'm relying on you: if you do as I say, we keep the money we have and we win as much again from the simpleton."[30]

"What do you want me to do?" asked his father.

"I buried the money," the swindler said, "at the foot of an imposing tree with a hollow a man can enter and hide in without being seen. I'd like you to go tonight and get inside the tree. Tomorrow, when the judge comes and asks the tree to testify, speak from inside the hollow, saying, 'The simpleton is the one who took the money.'"

"Son," said the swindler's father, "many a clever man has been undone by his own cunning. I'm afraid your cleverness will be like the heron's."[31]

"And how did his cleverness undo him?" he asked.

4.106 *The Heron, the Snake, and the Mongoose*

The swindler's father told the following tale: Once, they say, a heron had a snake for a neighbor. Whenever the heron had young to raise, the snake would go to the nest and eat them. The place suited the heron well, so he couldn't just leave it, but he was saddened by what the snake was doing to him. A crab, surmising what he was feeling, approached the heron and asked what was making him so sad. The heron told him what the snake had done and the crab said, "Shall I show you how you can take revenge on the snake?"

"How?" asked the heron.

The crab pointed to a burrow in front of him. "See that burrow? There is a mongoose in it, an enemy of snakes.[32] Gather lots of fish; put some of them by the mongoose's burrow and line up the rest between the mongoose's burrow and the snake's den. The mongoose will then kill the snake."

The heron did this, and the mongoose followed the fish to the snake and killed it. But then, out of habit, the mongoose came back, searching for more fish. When he didn't find any, he kept searching until he stumbled upon the heron's nearby nest, and devoured both the heron and his young.

"I've told you this story to show that if you aren't careful you risk landing yourself in worse trouble than you planned to inflict on the other person." **4.107**

"I hear what you're saying," said the swindler, "but don't be afraid! It's easier than you imagine."

So the old man, following his son's wishes, went to the tree, and got inside. The next morning, the judge, the swindler, and the simpleton came to the tree. The judge asked it, "Do you have any testimony?"

"Yes," replied the old man. "The simpleton took the money."

Amazed and incredulous, the judge began looking hard and trying to figure it out. He walked around the tree and noticed the hollow, but saw nothing because the man was too high up inside to be seen. So he ordered that firewood be gathered and lit, so as to fill the hollow with smoke. The swindler's father held out for a time, but finally, overcome, he cried out for help. On the judge's order, he was pulled out—just as he was dying. The swindler was punished, forfeited the money, and went home carrying his dead father on his back.

Kalīlah said, "I've told you this story to show you that someone who practices cunning and deception is often himself the loser. You, Dimnah, combine deceit and incompetence. Now you've seen the consequences of your deeds, and you're unlikely to come out unscathed. Such is the end of people who act as wrongfully as you have. You are two-tongued, two-faced, and duplicitous. River water, they say, is sweet until it reaches the sea and mixes with it; a family lives in happiness, prosperity, and unity until a wicked man sows discord among them; and friends remain friends until **4.108**

a two-tongued person comes between them. Nothing is more like a snake than a two-tongued man. A snake has two tongues, and what drips from them is venom, just like yours. I've always been afraid of the venom of your tongue, fearful that it would infect me with evil; I've been reluctant to be near you, mindful of the warning of the wise: Keep away from dissolute people though they be your own kin or companions. Such a companion or friend is like a snake: its owner raises it and treats it with kindness, but all he gets from it is a bite.

4.109 "They also say: Cleave to the intelligent and generous man, cultivate his company, and don't part from him. There is no harm in associating with an intelligent man, even if his character leaves something to be desired: guard yourself from his vices, but benefit from his intelligence. Likewise, do not spurn the generous man, even if his intelligence leaves something to be desired: benefit from his generosity and help him with your intelligence. But shun completely the man who is both low-minded and foolish. Thus, it is right for me to shun and avoid you. How can your friends expect loyalty and generosity, now that I've seen what you have done to your king, who was generous to you and raised you to honor? In this respect, what the merchant said applies to you: 'In a land where rats can eat a hundredweight of iron, there is nothing preposterous about hawks carrying off elephants!'"

"And how does that saying apply to me?" asked Dimnah.

4.110 *The Mice Who Ate a Hundredweight of Iron*

And Kalīlah told the following tale: In a certain land, they say, lived a merchant who, having exhausted his wealth, decided to travel abroad to seek his livelihood. He had in his possession an iron rod weighing a hundred *mann*,[33] which he left with an acquaintance for safekeeping, then set out. After a while he returned and asked for the rod, but the acquaintance, who he discovered had sold the iron and spent the proceeds, said to him, "I put your rod to one side in the house but the rats ate it up."

"Indeed," said the merchant, "I've heard that nothing cuts iron better than rats' teeth. A small loss! Thank God you're well."

4.111 Delighted by the merchant's reaction, the acquaintance said, "Come stay with me today."

The merchant left, promising to come back. But he carried off his friend's young son, hid him, and then returned. The boy's father missed his son and asked him, "Have you seen my son?"

"As I was approaching your house," replied the merchant, "I saw a hawk carry off a young boy. Perhaps it was your son."

"Who has ever seen or heard of hawks carrying off young boys?" the man cried out.

"Surely," replied the merchant, "in a land where rats can eat a hundred *mann* of iron, there is nothing preposterous about hawks carrying off elephants!"

And the acquaintance said, "It was I who 'ate up' your iron—I consumed what wasn't lawful for me to take. Give me back my son, and take your iron."

Kalīlah said, "I've told you this story to demonstrate that if you can betray your king, who has shown you such favor, you're sure to betray others. I see that love means nothing to you. Nothing is more wasted than love bestowed on someone who knows no loyalty, than favors bestowed on someone who knows no gratitude, than instruction given to someone who won't listen or benefit from it, or than a secret entrusted to someone who knows no discretion. I have no illusions about changing your nature: I know that a bitter tree can be smeared with honey and butter but will still produce bitter fruit. I fear the effect your company might have on my judgment and character; for the company of the good bestows goodness, while the company of the evil bestows evil. It is like the wind: if it wafts over something rotten, it spreads a stench; and if it wafts over something fragrant, it spreads a fragrance. I know how heavy my words will seem to you, but the foolish always make light of the wise, and the base make light of the noble. The crooked must be set straight by the upright, and impulsive fools brought back to their senses by the thoughtful. The low-minded never cease from attacking and denigrating the noble, the spineless from attacking the resolute, the rancorous from attacking the affectionate, the miserly from attacking the generous, and the vicious from attacking the righteous." **4.112**

Kalīlah's words reached this point just as the lion finished dealing with the ox. After he had killed the ox and his anger had subsided, the lion thought to himself, "He was a creature of intelligence, good judgment, and character. For all I know, he may have been an innocent victim of injustice." And he became filled with sadness and regret. **4.113**

When Dimnah noticed the lion's mood, he stopped talking to Kalīlah and approached the lion. "Now that God has given you the upper hand and enabled you to defeat your enemy, what is making you sad?"

"I grieve over the loss of Shanzabah's intelligence," replied the lion, "and I feel pity for him because of his good character."

"Don't feel pity for him," said Dimnah. "A wise man shows no mercy to **4.114** someone he fears. Someone who is prudent sometimes takes a dislike and forms an aversion to a man, but then, albeit reluctantly, treats him generously, draws him close, and appoints him to office because he knows the man's usefulness and merit—just as you force yourself to swallow a loathsome medicine because of its benefit. And sometimes you like a man and esteem him, but then you banish him, cast him aside, and destroy him, fearing harm from him—just as someone whose finger has been bitten by a snake will cut it off and throw it away for fear that the poison may spread throughout his body and kill him."

The lion acknowledged the truth of his words. Later, however, he investigated the matter of the ox and how Dimnah had wronged him. Everything became clear to him, and he put Dimnah to a most horrible death.

Then the philosopher said to the king, "There are marvels for intelligent **4.115** people in this story of how Dimnah, young and weak as he was and among the most contemptible and despised of beasts, managed to separate the lion and the ox, so that they abandoned their friendship, each turning against the other and becoming filled with rancor and aversion. One learns to beware of slanderers, deceivers, sowers of discord, enviers, and insolent men, and to guard against their falsities, deceits, trickeries, and calumnies. Those with intelligence must guard against the fabrications and lies of such people. They should scrutinize their actions and accept their words only after proper investigation, and they should reject all people they know to be of this sort. Sound judgment and prudence lie in caution and in emulating people who are pleasing to God."[34]

Here ends the Chapter of the Lion and the Ox.[35]